Chap. The officers under his command knew that come what may, both the corps commander and the army commander would back them to the hilt.

‘I will accept battle casualties,’ Bikram Singh had told his staff, ‘but I will not accept frostbite cases.’

Around this time, the land route over Zojila was made operational, considerably changing the equation. Despite the logistical nightmare of maintaining troops in the expanse of Ladakh and Nubra, XV Corps’ logistic arm headed by Brigadier J. M. Das rose superbly to the occasion. Initially commissioned into the Army Supply Corps, Das had shifted to the armoured corps. Along with a small band of officers, he took pains to understand the terrain and the logistical support that was required.

CHINESE CHECKERS

By 1955, it was obvious to the Chinese that a road link to Lhasa from either eastern or northern Tibet would be problematic. Hence, they had turned their attention to the west. However, in this region bordering the Indian state of Jammu and Kashmir, it was felt that militarily India had the upper hand. Keeping the Indians off balance in NEFA was possible from Chinese military bases in Yunnan, but for them to be tackled in Jammu and Kashmir (specifically in Nubra and Ladakh) China had to develop a road linking Sinkiang and Western Tibet along an existing caravan track that passed through Haji Langar (Aksai Chin) exiting Indian territory at a point about thirty kilometres to the northeast of Lanak-la.

Sinkiang had always been strategically important; for the Russians it was the buffer between themselves and the expanding power from the east —the Japanese. The Chinese on the other hand were keen to subjugate Sinkiang to settle part of their own fast expanding population. The discovery of large reserves of thorium and uranium in the region further strengthened China’s desire to control the region administratively and militarily. Not too surprisingly, Mao’s first move on overthrowing Chiang Kai-Shek was to annex Sinkiang. At that point of time, Sinkiang was connected to China by a 1,000-kilometre caravan route that crossed the Taklamakan Desert, any part of which could have been cut off by the Russians.

We’ve seen earlier the confusion on the boundary between India and China. This allowed the latter to build the road through Aksai Chin, quite convinced that when the time came, Nehru could be persuaded to accept it.